ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
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An invitation

وَأَنِرْ أَبْصَارَ قُلُوبِنَا بِضِيَاءِ نَظَرِهَا إِلَيْكَ حَتَّىٰ تَخْرِقَ أَبْصَارُ الْقُلُوبِ حُجُبَ النُّورِ فَتَصِلَ إِلَىٰ مَعْدِنِ الْعَظَمَةِ

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.[1]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

What is ʿirfan?

These words come from the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, a prayer many of us recite in the month of Shaʿban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through even the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. It is a request to see God with the heart and to be near Him. Requests like this one were written for us, by the Imams (as), as an endeavour for the ordinary believer.

Despite saying these words in our munajats and on auspicious occasions, we find that seeking to know God does not feature in our day-to-day routine. Praying, fasting, and paying what is due, the *wajibat*, are the dominant undertaking, and they are what most of us mean by practising the religion. The other side, the one the Munajat describes, in which the believer seeks to know God

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

and to come near Him, is often less practised. That side of the religion is called *ʿirfan*.

ʿIrfan is the Arabic name for what English books call Islamic mysticism, and the two words do not say the same thing. "Mysticism" suggests mystery, something hidden and hard to pin down. The Arabic word names a kind of knowing. It shares its root with *maʿrifah*, knowledge, and an *ʿarif* is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "someone who knows".

The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is knowing Him from close, with the heart, which is what the Munajat asks for. In Murtada Mutahhari's words, the ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[2]. ʿIrfan is that knowing, and the training of the soul that makes it possible. It is part of the Islam we already know: its sources are the Qur'an and the words of the Imams, and the prayer at the head of this page is one of them.

This book argues that this side of the religion is worth every believer's pursuit. ʿIrfan travels through the self and never leaves the shariʿa. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. It is rooted in the Qur'an and the Imams. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and to God Himself.

Who this book is for

The argument is addressed to anyone who prays, fasts, and recites the duʿas, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right; whether the religion has another dimension. No knowledge of ʿirfan, of philosophy, or of Arabic is assumed. The book is meant as a welcoming introduction to ʿirfan, a guide to beginning the journey that strives for brevity and clarity. Each chapter opens with a section that details some of the words you'll meet, along with an explanation; all terms are gathered in the glossary at the end. Additional call-out sections are spread throughout with helpful context and short side notes.

[2]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

How the book is built

The book is built in five parts. Each answers one question and depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters One to Three), asks why a believer should bother. It answers that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. The goal of ʿirfan is already on our lips in our duʿas.

Part Two, *Getting Ready* (Chapters Four to Seven), describes the landscape a traveller passes through on the journey towards ʿirfan: the self. It also sets out the boundary that keeps the traveller safe, the shariʿa, and the guide who walks alongside.

Part Three, *The Road* (Chapters Eight to Twelve), asks how the path is walked: through ordered stages, by repentance, discipline, and love, to the loss of the false self.

Part Four, *Fellow Travellers* (Chapters Thirteen to Fifteen), meets those who walked the road before us. It shows the road's roots in the Qur'an and the Imams, where its travellers arrived, and how Shia ʿirfan relates to Sufism.

Part Five, *The Destination* (Chapters Sixteen and Seventeen), asks what the road is for. The friends of God return to people, with God; every soul returns to God.

Where this book comes from

This book is inspired by a lecture series on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour. The content and structure of those lectures are the core of the book. Wherever the Sheikh is quoted directly, the words are his own, from that series.

Turning spoken lectures into a book has called for some editorial adaptation. To suit a wider readership, the book also adds context and explanation to support its main arguments. It draws on a wider literature as well: the words of the Imams in Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya, and the supplications of the Mafatih; then the great Shia teachers of the path, from Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century to modern scholars such as Mirza Jawad

Maliki Tabrizi, ʿAllama Tabataba'i, Imam Khomeini, and Ayatullah Mutahhari. Every source is given in a footnote, for readers who want to go further.

The finer questions of ʿirfan remain an ongoing conversation among our *ʿulama'*: whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, how far ordinary believers can travel. Where they differ, this book presents each view with neutrality.

What you can expect

Three guiding principles frame the discussions in the chapters that follow. The first is that ʿirfan is never pursued for the sake of powers, such as reading minds or foreseeing future events. Sheikh Bahmanpour and the wider literature agree on this, as Chapter One shows.

The second is that there is no separate sect or order through which ʿirfan must be gained. Shia ʿirfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam. How this position differs from that of the Sufi orders is explored in Chapter Fifteen.

The third principle is the most important: no part of the journey towards ʿirfan requires stepping outside the shariʿa, and nothing on that journey is gained by doing so. The beginning of ʿirfan, as the Sheikh puts it, is the shariʿa. The inner path does not go around the law or rise above it; it is the law lived from the inside. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marjaʿ. A fear that mysticism might do exactly that is one reason some scholars have been wary of ʿirfan. Chapter Fourteen sets out their wider concerns, with the answers given to them.

By the end, a reader should feel able to say what ʿirfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path entail. For those who wish to go further, each chapter and the epilogue offer small, practical steps for bringing this into daily life alongside the wajibat.

PART ONE

The Call

Why travel?

The Qur’an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. That knowing is reached by purifying the heart, and our own prayers already ask for it.

1 · More than the minimum
2 · Knowing about God is not knowing Him
3 · You already know these words

إِلٰهِي لَمْ يَكُنْ لِي حَوْلٌ فَأَنْتَقِلَ بِهِ عَنْ مَعْصِيَتِكَ إِلاَّ فِي وَقْتٍ أَيْقَظْتَنِي لِمَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, I was not strong enough to move away from Your disobedience, except when You awakened me to Your love.

Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

1

More than the minimum

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Qur'an 30:21

There is a verse often recited at weddings, one most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves "that you may take comfort in them", and that He ordained "affection and mercy" between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words above: this is a sign for a people who reflect. Whether a person sees it depends on something in the person doing the looking. That something, and why it is worth developing, is the subject of this chapter.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'Irfan*: knowing God from close · *ma'rifah*: knowledge of God · *'arif* (plural *'urafa'*): one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya' Allah*: the friends of God · *shirk*: setting up a partner beside God

What the minimum leaves out

Let's start with two claims. The first is that a believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due, and goes on hajj can hope for *jannah*, provided they do what is *wajib* and avoid what is forbidden. This claim is not contested. Sheikh Bahmanpour accepts it as fair for ordinary believers. Mohammad Ali Shomali makes the same point, describing the obligatory rules of fiqh as "the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection"[3].

The second claim goes further, and it is the one this book disputes. Some jurists and activists hold that the obligatory acts are the whole of the religion; anything beyond them, they say, is made up by the whims and wishes of certain mystics.

To see why there is more than the obligations, let's turn to the Qur'an and read on from the verse this chapter began with. Surah al-Rum names three more sets of signs: the creation of the heavens and the earth, with the variety of our languages and colours; our sleep and our work; the lightning, and the rain that revives the dead earth (Q 30:22–24). Each verse ends as the first did, by saying who the sign is for.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

Qur'an 30:22

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

Qur'an 30:23

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Qur'an 30:24

[3]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

Four times in a row, the Qur'an makes the same point. The signs are all around us: in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work, in the weather. Yet they are for those who reflect, know, listen, and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening, and reasoning is what the Qur'an asks of us beyond the minimum.

For the avoidance of doubt, this invitation from the Qur'an is not an invitation to circumvent the law or to abandon the prescribed wajibat. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"[4]. Within those bounds, the Qur'an is just as insistent, in these verses and others, that it invites us to more than the obligatory acts.

Signs most people miss

An invitation addressed to those who reflect, know, listen, and reason implies that many people do none of these things. This is not limited to the careless. Most pious people, even those careful about the shariʿa, do not find a sign in these verses. Looking at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

We have heard these verses many times, and we accept that there are signs in them because the Qur'an says so; yet accepting that a sign exists is not the same as perceiving it. The Qur'an describes the gap in one verse.

وَكَأَيِّن مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ ﴿١٠٥﴾

How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass by while they are disregardful of it!

Qur'an 12:105

ʿAllama Tabataba'i explains what passing by a sign means; a person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and "what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator"[5]. Most of us see only the lamp. We witness the rain as rain and the marriage as a marriage, and we pass them by without perceiving what they say about their Creator.

[4]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

[5]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.

The fault is in the receiver

If the signs are present and plain, and yet we still pass them by, the fault is on our side. The Qur'an says where it lies, speaking of people who have every faculty and use none of them.

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ ءَاذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَآ ۚ
أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ كَٱلْأَنْعَٰمِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray.

Qur'an 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. It is about what lies behind the senses. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things, whereas inside a human being there should be something more: a faculty, which animals lack, that turns what the senses take in into understanding. In most of us, it is not working.

Sheikh Bahmanpour compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but "there is something inside which doesn't catch it. There is a machine inside which is [rusted]." That machine is the soul. It has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. This is the whole subject in one sentence: mysticism is about making the soul hear, see, and reflect. It is not easy, and it requires a great deal of training.

Placing the fault in the receiver has two consequences. The first is that the problem is not a shortage of evidence. God is not withholding signs; we are failing to receive them.

The second is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but has rusted can be repaired; one that is absent cannot be made fit for purpose. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of 'Allama Tabataba'i's early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is "part of the innate instincts of the human being"[6]. The longing for God, and the faculty that perceives Him, are part of how we are made.

[6] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 4.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, the journey begins, and it does not end; it is, in the Sheikh's words, a path that "has a beginning and no end".

Some do see

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it already works. The Qur'an describes them more than once. People can be divided into two groups: those whose souls work, and those whose souls do not. The first group are the *'urafa'*, the plural of *'arif*. The prophets and the Imams (as) are a class of their own; the 'urafa' are ordinary believers who see more than the rest. The first description of them is in Surah al-Anfal.

إِنَّمَا ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ ٱلَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ ٱللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned,

Qur'an 8:2

A heart trembles only at the mention of someone it has some experience of; a name means little to a person who does not know whom it names. The believers of this verse are thus the believers who know Allah. A verse in Surah Al 'Imran goes further, giving them another name.

شَهِدَ ٱللَّهُ أَنَّهُۥ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَٱلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ وَأُو۟لُوا۟ ٱلْعِلْمِ

Allah ... bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Qur'an 3:18

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads "those who possess knowledge" as another name for the 'urafa'. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah. Our knowledge of *tawhid*, God's oneness, is still not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp; the intellect alone cannot reach its depths, and only the awakened soul can. Surah Fatir describes the same people by what they feel.

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى ٱللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ ٱلْعُلَمَٰٓؤُا۟

Only those of Allah's servants having knowledge fear Him.

Qur'an 35:28

Most of us fear Allah's punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all.

Surah Yunus gives them another name: the *awliya' Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62). Imam ʿAli (as) describes what these friends see that others miss.

God's special devotees are those who perceive the world's reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.[7]

Nahj al-Balagha

Other people look at the surface of the world; the friends of God look at what lies inside it. This does not mean turning away from the world. There is nothing wrong with pursuing material wealth in this life; the trouble is being solely occupied with it. The friends of God have families, friends, and a place in society, as we do. They think not about themselves but about God, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to all

The Qur'an also tells us what these people receive. The first gift is nearness: Surah al-Waqiʿa sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places the Foremost Ones.

وَٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ ٱلْمُقَرَّبُونَ ﴿١١﴾

And the Foremost Ones are the foremost ones: they are the ones brought near [to Allah],

Qur'an 56:10-11

[7] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

The Arabic for “brought near” is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone; being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, so that they understand far more.

The second gift is a different kind of life, promised in Surah al-Nahl to whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَٰلِحًا مِّن ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهُۥ حَيَوٰةً طَيِّبَةً ۖ

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life

Qur’an 16:97

This good life, *hayat tayyiba*, is a clean life. Its people live in the world without being soiled by it, rising above the worries that occupy everyone else. It is this good life that the mystics seek.

The third gift is peace, promised in the verse of Surah Yunus that names the friends of God.

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Qur’an 10:62

For the muqarrabun, the terms are entirely different from those of ordinary believers.

None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa’ answers that concern.

وَمَن يُطِعِ ٱللَّهَ وَٱلرَّسُولَ فَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ مَعَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِم مِّنَ ٱلنَّبِيِّـۧنَ وَٱلصِّدِّيقِينَ وَٱلشُّهَدَآءِ وَٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Qur'an 4:69

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this verse as naming four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada'*, which the translation used here renders "martyrs" and which he takes as "the witnesses"; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks are beyond us; the fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and from among them God chooses the truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

That doorway is open to people like us: ordinary people can also enter the realm of the muqarrabun. It is difficult, but it is open, because we are made for it. We call ourselves human beings, yet, in the Sheikh's words, "we are not yet human beings". We begin with the potential to become human in the full sense that the prophets are. He means this as a statement of what we were made for. A human being has the capacity to become a friend of God; God created us with that capacity, and wants us to reach it.

This is the case for pursuing 'irfan. The Qur'an invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. That rank is open to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

The aim is God, not powers

Pursuing 'irfan means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul in an attempt to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, or to master the hidden world of the soul. This kind of mysticism must be held apart from the real thing. Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

Sheikh Bahmanpour ended his first lecture more strongly. ʿIrfan "is not about any type of power or empowering the soul" to work *karamat* and *muʿjizat*, the wonders of the saints and the miracles of the prophets. Then: "These are shirk." *Shirk*, setting up a partner beside God, is the gravest charge in Islam.

The great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points, each in his own words. ʿAllama Tabataba'i tells the traveller that he "has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities", nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so "does not move on the path of the Beloved's pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God". It is his own self that he worships, "though he may not admit it by word of mouth"[8].

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: ʿALLAMA TABATABA'I**
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> Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba'i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Qur'an in twenty volumes[9]. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown "with the two wings of knowledge and action". He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ʿAli Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he "came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur'an"[10]. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani's record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba'i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50[11]. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*[12], from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"[13].

[8] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 28–29.
[9] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.
[10] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 8.
[11] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 9.
[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.
[13] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

Murtada Mutahhari uses the same word as Sheikh Bahmanpour. The ʻurafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself", and he recalls Imam ʻAli (as) saying that he worshipped God not from fear of His Fire or desire for His Paradise but because he found Him worthy of worship[14].

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Mutahhari also explains why seeking them would be shirk: the goal has become something other than God.

Seeking, and nothing else

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gave at the end of his first lecture: ʻirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". It seeks two things: *maʻrifah*, the knowledge of God; and the love of God.

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʻIRFAN AND MAʻRIFAH**
> *ʻIrfan*, *maʻrifah*, *ʻarif* and its plural *ʻurafa'* belong to one family of words about knowing. An ʻarif, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is "someone who knows". "Mystic" is used of Christians, Hindus, and Buddhists alike; ʻarif is the Islamic word, and it makes a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ʻarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[15]. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), says that there is no way to God except through knowledge[16]. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter Two.

ʻAllama Tabataba'i's definition agrees: "The real gnostic is he who worships Allah not, because he hopes for any reward or is afraid of any punishment, but only because he knows Him and loves Him"[17].

ʻIrfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what kind of knowing is that?

[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.
[15] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʻa), p. 9.
[17] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

➤ TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour built his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen, and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.

2

Knowing about God is not knowing Him

On a day of fasting in Ramadan, by late afternoon, no one has to be told that they are hungry. They do not read it in a book or work it out from the clock. The hunger is known from the inside. Sheikh Bahmanpour uses hunger to describe a kind of knowing that differs from the kind gained by study.

Most of what we know of God is of the kind gained by study. We learn the rulings of fiqh, the beliefs the scholars set out, and the history of the Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (as); all of it is knowledge about God. Chapter One argued that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum, and that the aim is to know and love God. The 'knowing' it refers to is the kind of knowing that a fasting person has of their hunger: knowing God directly, and not only knowing about Him.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'ilm*: knowledge, especially knowledge gained by study · *'ilm al-husuli*: acquired knowledge · *'ilm al-huduri*: knowledge by presence · *'aql*: the reasoning intellect · *suluk*: wayfaring; the path of purification

Knowing about, and knowing

Let's start with the two kinds of knowing. The first is acquired knowledge, *'ilm al-husuli*. It reaches us from outside, through the senses or by reasoning.

We form concepts of the things around us and then analyse those concepts. Almost everything we learn from teachers and books is of this kind.

Acquired knowledge works by defining its object. To understand a thing, we sort it into a category and mark where it ends and something else begins. The Arabic for a definition, *hadd*, also means a limit: to define a thing is to limit it. The old definition of a human being as "the rational animal" works by drawing a line round us.

The second kind is knowledge by presence, *'ilm al-huduri*. It does not come from outside and needs no concept to carry it; it is with the soul already. The plainest case is our knowledge of our own self. Hunger, the example this chapter opened with, is another, and so are pain and anxiety. Anxiety has a cause outside us, yet the feeling arises inside the soul, and the cause is not the feeling.

Knowledge by presence is complete in a way that acquired knowledge is not. When the body is hungry, the soul knows it at once and without effort, and nothing of the hunger is missed. The Sheikh adds that the hunger may even be false, and yet what is felt is real. The point is worth drawing out. A person who has eaten enough can still feel hungry, and no one can argue them out of the feeling. They may be wrong to think that their body needs food. They cannot be wrong that they feel hungry.

This second kind of knowing is what the mystics are after. Sheikh Bahmanpour defines mysticism as the urge to reach out to the infinite through knowledge by presence. The two kinds of knowing aim at different things: *'ilm* aims at understanding, and *ma'rifah* aims at arriving. A person does not try to understand their hunger; they arrive at it and feel it. In the same way, the mystic's aim is to arrive at God and not to define Him, since a God who has been defined has been limited.

Imam Khomeini records the same distinction, citing the view that a gnostic of God "knows God through direct witnessing", while a scholar of God "attains the knowledge of God through philosophical proofs"[18].

ع WORD STUDY: 'ILM AL-HUSULI AND 'ILM AL-HUDURI

[18]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.

Husul means acquiring or obtaining, whereas *hudur* means presence. In *ʿilm al-husuli*, acquired knowledge, what reaches the mind is a concept or an image of the thing, while the thing itself stays outside. In *ʿilm al-huduri*, knowledge by presence, the thing known is itself present to the soul, as our own self, our hunger, and our pain are present. Imam Khomeini's word for the gnostic's witnessing, *huduriyya*, comes from the same root. The religious texts use *ʿilm* and *maʿrifah* for the same thing; this book keeps them apart only to make the two kinds of knowing easier to see. Chapter One's Word Study noted that there is no way to God except through knowledge, and left open what type of knowledge it refers to; it assuredly refers to knowledge by presence.

Where reason stops

Acquired knowledge is the work of reason, *ʿaql*, the faculty by which we understand and argue. Reason has a limit. When we know a thing, we know its attributes: its colour, its size, and what it does. Reason does not reach the thing that carries those attributes. Every description says that it is brown or square or useful, and none says what the "it" is. Ibn Sina, the greatest of the Muslim philosophers, granted this. The reality of things, he held, is beyond the reach of human reason.

If this is true of the things around us, it is true far more of God. God has no colour or size for the mind to take hold of, and no boundary for a definition to draw. Imam ʿAli (as) says as much at the opening of the first oration in *Nahj al-Balagha*, where he praises God.

> *Soaring thoughts cannot reach him and deep minds cannot fathom him.*[19]
>
> Nahj al-Balagha

The Imam's two images, soaring and depth, name the two strengths of reason, its range and its penetration, and neither arrives at God. The next sentence of the oration gives the reason. God, it says, "cannot be described, for he is beyond the limits of demarcated boundaries"[20].

[19] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.
[20] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.

What reason can do, it does. It can show that God exists, and it can say what He is not: He is not a body, He is not in one place and absent from another, and He has no partner. All of this is true, and all of it is knowledge about God. It is also negative knowledge: each statement says what God is not, and none says what He is.

'Irfan asks for the positive side, to know God as the Merciful, the Compassionate, and the Forgiving. The names can be learned from a book. To know God as Merciful from within, as a hungry person knows their hunger, is the other kind of knowing, the knowledge by presence of this chapter's first section.

Positive knowledge of this kind can only be knowledge by presence, and we have knowledge by presence only of what is within us: our own self and some of its states. Mulla Sadra held that knowledge by presence is the only way to know the reality of anything, God above all. If God is to be known, and not only known about, the knowing must happen within the soul.

The soul is not an empty place to look. A sense of God already lives there, however faint; Sheikh Bahmanpour calls it a vague idea of God that we carry inside us, present and mostly unnoticed. The answer to how God can be known lies in a soul we have hardly begun to know.

◈ WHO'S WHO: MULLA SADRA AND THE SCHOOLS OF PHILOSOPHY

Mulla Sadra died in 1050/1640[21]. Before him, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Islamic philosophy had two main schools, the Peripatetic, *al-hikma al-mashsha'iyya*, and the Illuminationist. The Peripatetic school is the way of reasoned proof that Murtada Mutahhari describes: the philosopher works with "reason, deductions and proofs"[22]. It is the school of Ibn Sina. Mulla Sadra called his own philosophy neither of these but the transcendent philosophy, *al-hikma al-muta'aliya*. He took what the mystics know only by experience and gave it rational argument, a rationalised mysticism, and held that the reality of things is known only through knowledge by presence. Put simply, the Peripatetics reason their way to the truth, whereas Mulla Sadra held that reasoning must end in the soul's own presence to what it knows. He studied the 'irfan of Ibn 'Arabi deeply without belonging to any Sufi order, and rated Ibn 'Arabi above Ibn Sina[23]. *Kernel of the Kernels* records that after a lifetime in philosophy he be-

[21] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 40.
[22] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[23] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 35, 40.

came absorbed in worship and the purification of his inner being, until “it became clear to me that their syllogisms were barren and their path devoid of straightness”[24].

Light in the heart

Knowledge that cannot be produced from analysis, and that has to be found within the soul, must be placed there. A hadith on knowledge, which Imam Khomeini quotes in his *Forty Hadith*, says by whom.

Knowledge is not extensive learning. Rather, it is a light that God casts in the heart of whomever He wills.[25]

Hadith

The hadith sets the two kinds of knowing side by side. Extensive learning is acquired knowledge, gathered from outside. The light is not gathered at all; God places it in the heart.

The words “whomever He wills” raise a question: does God keep His light for a chosen few? Sheikh Bahmanpour speaks of the light differently, and he does so with a verse of Surah al-Nur.

ٱللَّهُ نُورُ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ ۚ

Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth.

Qur’an 24:35

Allah’s light is everywhere, in the heavens and in the earth, and He is with us wherever we are. He does not pick out some people for light and pass over others; nothing is held back on His side. The heart is what is closed, and the work of the ‘urafa’ is to open it and let the light in.

Imam Khomeini explains why purification matters so much. When the soul is purified, he writes, divine teaching follows, “for there is no niggardli-

[24] ʿAllama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 7.
[25] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

ness in the higher realms, which are bounteous by necessity"[26]. He grounds this in a promise of Surah al-Baqarah.

وَٱتَّقُواْ ٱللَّهَ ۖ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ ٱللَّهُ ۗ

Be wary of Allah and Allah will teach you.

Qur'an 2:282

In the verse, God's teaching follows on from wariness of Him.

The hadith and the verse of Surah al-Nur can seem to pull in different directions. The hadith says that God casts the light into the heart of whomever He wills, as if He chose some hearts over others. The verse says that His light is everywhere already. Both are true. Every act is God's, including the lighting of any heart, and nothing happens except by His will. His will, however, is not to withhold: His light is given without stint. What keeps a heart dark is that it is closed, and purification is what opens it to a light that was always there.

The light comes to the hearts of the pure, and darkness covers the impure. Chapter One reached the same conclusion by a different road. Surah al-Rum says that God's signs are for those who reflect, know, listen, and reason, and yet most people pass them by. Nothing in the signs is hidden and nothing is wrong with our eyes; the fault lies with an inner faculty that has rusted and does not receive.

A light received in one heart can reach another. We are familiar with knowledge passing from one mind to another, through speech and writing; we are less familiar with knowledge passing from one heart to another. The knowledge of the 'urafa' passes, in the Sheikh's words, "from heart to heart", and not from mind to mouth. Receiving it directly from God is possible but difficult, and most travellers begin through someone who has already received it. Chapter Seven returns to that companion.

The path is purification

If the light is everywhere and the heart is closed, the path to knowing God is the opening of the heart. Two words name the difference. Knowledge learned

[26]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

at a university or a seminary comes through *fikr*, thought: we think, put things together, analyse, and find out. Knowledge of God comes through *suluk*, wayfaring, which the Sheikh describes as the path to purity; a striving towards purification. Murtada Mutahhari draws the same contrast. The philosopher, he writes, works with reason, deductions, and proofs, while the means of the ʿarif are "the heart and the purification, disciplining and perfecting of the self"[27].

The knowledge of ʿirfan cannot be worked out, and so it comes through suluk. In the Sheikh's words, "You purify yourself and then wait for Allah to put the light in your heart." The waiting is not for a light that is absent. It is the patience of a heart that has done its part and leaves the rest to God, whose light never stops.

Purification begins with the shariʿa. Its first step is to polish the soul by doing whatever the Prophet ﷺ has asked, and without this there is no maʿrifah. The Qur'an calls the believers to answer Allah and the Apostle when he summons them to what will give them life (Q 8:24). That life, the Sheikh says, comes when a person follows the Prophet completely. Practising the shariʿa is the first purification of the heart.

Practice depends on knowing what to practise, and this is where study comes in. ʿAllama Tabataba'i, in the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, places it at the start. The first essential for the traveller, he says, is knowledge of the rules of the shariʿa, learned from a jurist. The traveller puts that knowledge into practice and persists until conviction and gnosis grow by degrees, "for knowledge gives birth to action and action in turn brings knowledge"[28]. Learning starts the circle, practice purifies the heart, and the purified heart receives a deeper knowledge, which leads to better practice.

Imam Khomeini gives study its place, with a warning. A learning that does not bring faith with it, he writes, "is the greatest of veils"; yet "one has to approach a veil in order to tear it into shreds"[29]. In his account, learning about God comes first, and exercises and austerities then open the heart[30].

[27] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[28] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 56.
[29] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.
[30] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah ties the light to the path in one line.

إِنَّ مَنِ ٱنْتَهَجَ بِكَ لَمُسْتَنِيرٌ

One who follows Your path is enlightened.[31]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The prologue opened on a line from this prayer that asks for the eyes of the heart to be lit until they reach the source of God's grandeur. This line names who receives that light: the one who follows God's path.

STORY: THE PHILOSOPHER AND THE ʿARIF

Murtada Mutahhari records a meeting between Ibn Sina and Abu Saʿid ibn Abi al-Khayr, one of the most famous of all the ʿurafa'. Abu Saʿid was preaching on the necessity of deeds, and on obedience and disobedience to God. Ibn Sina answered him with a quatrain (a poem of four lines). Wherever God's favour and grace are found, it ran, "Let the not-done be like the done, the done like the not-done." The verse leaned on God's forgiveness in place of deeds. Abu Saʿid replied at once with a quatrain of his own, which ends: "Do not rely on forgiveness, for never / Was the not-done like the done, the done like the not-done"[32]. The ʿarif would not let a verse, however well turned, take the place of deeds. Mutahhari adds that towards the end of his life Ibn Sina "developed mystic inclinations"[33].

Knowing by drawing near

Those brought near to God, the ʿurafa', know Him by presence, through a veil removed and not a definition learned. Their knowing is present to the soul, as hunger is present to the one who fasts, and it comes as a light that God gives to a purified heart. Knowing God therefore differs in kind from knowing about God. It is reached by purification; study, in the view of Imam Khomeini and ʿAllama Tabataba'i, serves it but cannot replace it.

Where, then, does an ordinary believer already stand on this path?

[31] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §88.

[32] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 29.

[33] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.

➤ TRY THIS

In every prostration of the daily prayer we say, “Glory belongs to my Lord, the Exalted, and Him do I praise.” ‘Allama Tabataba’i uses these words to show how knowledge follows action[34]. For one week, in one prayer each day, say them slowly, “believing it to be a fact”. Notice your own lowliness with your forehead on the ground, then the majesty of the One you are calling exalted. From “a very minor action, such as this dhikr said in prostration”, he says, a person comes to discover God’s absolute majesty[35].

[34] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 56–57.

[35] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 57.

3

You already know these words

وَّقَلْبِي بِحُبِّكَ مُتَيَّماً

And my heart enthralled by Your love![36]

Du'a Kumayl

These words come near the end of Du'a Kumayl, the prayer Imam 'Ali (as) taught to Kumayl ibn Ziyad, one of his closest disciples. The Mafatih al-Jinan recommends it on every Thursday evening, the night before Friday, when many of us hear it[37]. The line asks God for a heart enthralled by His love.

A request for God's love begins to answer the question Chapter Two ended on. That chapter argued that knowing God is reached by purifying the heart, and it asked where an ordinary believer already stands on this path. The words we already say ask for exactly what Chapter Two described. Du'a Kumayl asks for the love that goes with that knowing; other prayers we recite ask for the knowing itself. This chapter sets out what those prayers ask for.

[36] *Du'a Kumayl* (duas.org), §221.

[37] Shaykh 'Abbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *duʿa*: supplication, any request made to God · *munajat*: an intimate, whispered prayer to God · *Mafatih al-Jinan*: the standard manual of Shia prayers · *inqitaʿ*: severance of the heart from all but God

Cut off from all else

Let's start with the order in which the prayers ask. Sheikh Bahmanpour reads the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah as a sequence. Those who seek God want to know Him and to look at Him, but "they have to cut off from everything first". In the prayer, the request for light in the eyes of the heart, with which this book opened, follows straight on from a request to be cut off.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي كَمَالَ ٱلِانْقِطَاعِ إِلَيْكَ

My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relations with everything else[38]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The Arabic word for this severance is *inqitaʿ*, being cut off, and the Munajat asks for it in full. Taken at its word, the request could sound like a call to leave family, work, and society behind. The prayers themselves rule that reading out.

Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali, recited on the nights of Ramadan, names exactly what is to be cut away. "O my Master, (please) expel love for the world out of my heart," it asks (سَيِّدِي أَخْرِجْ حُبَّ ٱلدُّنْيَا مِنْ قَلْبِي)[39]. What the prayer asks to lose is the heart's love for the world, not the world itself, nor the people and the work in it.

Chapter One met the same severance in the friends of God. They keep their families, their friends, and their place in society, as we do; it is their hearts that are cut off from everything but God. The severance the prayers ask for is therefore in the heart, not in the household or the marketplace.

Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, describes this severance from the other side, as something God has already done for those He loves.

[38] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §104.

[39] *Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §384.

وَأَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَزَلْتَ ٱلأَغْيَارَ عَنْ قُلُوبِ أَحِبَّائِكَ حَتَّىٰ لَمْ يُحِبُّوا سِوَاكَ

It is You Who have removed love for others from the hearts of Your lovers so that they have loved none save You[40]

Duʿa ʿArafah

The line names God as the one who cleared these hearts. He removed love for others from them, and what remained was love for Him alone.

To see, to love, to draw near

A heart cleared of everything but God is free for Him. The prayers go on to ask for three things: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to come near Him. Let's take them in turn.

The first is sight. The Munajat asks God to light the eyes of the heart so that they look at Him, and pass even through the veils of light. The Sheikh raises the difficulty himself: the Qur'an says that sight cannot perceive God (Q 6:103), and some who meet these words take them for a mistake. In a later lecture he gives the answer. The eyes cannot catch Him; the prayer is speaking of the heart. Our physical eyes work perfectly well, and still we miss God's signs, because the inner faculty behind them is blind. The prayer asks God to give that inner faculty, the eye of the heart, light to see by.

Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, speaks of that light as something God has already lit in the hearts of His friends.

أَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَشْرَقْتَ ٱلأَنْوَارَ فِي قُلُوبِ أَوْلِيَائِكَ

It is You Who have lit the illuminations in the hearts of Your intimate servants[41]

Duʿa ʿArafah

The word translated "Your intimate servants" is *awliya'*, the friends of God whom Chapter One met in Surah Yunus. Chapter Two described a light that is everywhere and that a purified heart receives. This line says the same from the side of prayer: the lighting of any heart is God's act.

[40] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §783–784.
[41] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §781.

The second request is love. The Munajat asks for a place among God's friends, and it defines that place by love.

إِلٰهِي أَقِمْنِي فِي أَهْلِ وِلَايَتِكَ مُقَامَ مَنْ رَجَا ٱلزِّيَادَةَ مِنْ مَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, place me among Your friends in the position of one who hopes for an increase in Your love.[42]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The Sheikh reads the friendship asked for here, *wilaya*, as having two parts. One is maʿrifah: understanding God, looking at Him, and knowing Him. The other is love for Him, which is incessant, while the maʿrifah keeps increasing. These are the two aims Chapter One gave ʿirfan, and both are in one line of the Munajat.

The third request is nearness, and the Munajat makes it earlier in the same prayer.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي قَلْباً يُدْنِيهِ مِنْكَ شَوْقُهُ

My Lord, provide me with a heart, the passion of which may bring it near You[43]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

In this request the heart is brought near by its own passion for God. Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali goes further and asks to love the meeting with God itself. "O Lord of Glory and Honor, (please do) make me love meeting You," it says (يَا ذَا ٱلْجَلَالِ وَٱلْإِكْرَامِ حَبِّبْ إِلَيَّ لِقَاءَكَ)[44].

The Whispered Prayer of the Lovers asks for a place among those who have already been brought near. It is one of the fifteen whispered prayers printed with the Sahifa, and several of its lines were read in the lectures this book draws on.

[42]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §92–93.

[43]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §82.

[44]*Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §599.

My God, place us with him whom Thou hast chosen for Thy nearness and Thy friendship, ... granted gazing upon Thy face[45]

Whispered Prayer of the Lovers

For some of us, calling on God can feel like calling into the sky to someone far away. For others, God is present when they call, and they feel His response. The prayer asks to be placed with these: among those chosen for His nearness, and granted the sight of His face.

Murtada Mutahhari names these prayers together in his introduction to ʻirfan: Duʻa Kumayl, Duʻa Abu Hamza, the supplications of the Sahifa, and the Shaʻbaniyyah. They "all contain the most sublime spiritual ideas", he writes[46]. He cites them to show that ʻirfan has its sources inside Islam, with no need to look for its origin elsewhere.

A pupil reading above his level

Requests this high raise a difficulty, and Sheikh Bahmanpour states it himself. These words belong to the peak of the understanding and longing of the *muqarrabun*, those brought near to God, and he asks why we are told to recite them at all. Telling ordinary believers to say them, he says, is "like [telling] a primary school boy to read books of university".

The prayers themselves speak from need, as a pupil would. Duʻa ʻArafah, as given in the Mafatih, comes to God with nothing to offer but its need of Him.

هَا أَنَا أَتَوَسَّلُ إِلَيْكَ بِفَقْرِي إِلَيْكَ

Here I am begging You by my need for You.[47]

Duʻa ʻArafah

Duʻa Abu Hamza al-Thumali makes the same plea, and places the one who prays at a door. "O my Master, I, Your servant, am standing at Your door owing to neediness," it says (سَيِّدِي عَبْدُكَ بِبَابِكَ أَقَامَتْهُ ٱلْخَصَاصَةُ بَيْنَ يَدَيْكَ)[48]. The servant stands there because of need, and the prayer gives no other reason for coming.

[45] Imam Zayn al-ʻAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 656.
[46] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 20.
[47] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʻa ʻArafah* (duas.org), §689.
[48] *Duʻa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §510.

The line at the head of Part One takes this humility further. In it the Munajat admits that the one reciting had no strength to move away from disobedience "except when You awakened me to Your love"[49]. Even the turning towards God is His doing.

The answer to the difficulty rests on the same humility. We do not understand many of the meanings of these words, which are above our level and beyond our capacity, yet not understanding them does not make them meaningless. We have been honoured, because we are allowed to recite them. God invites the reciter to come and say them, and if the reciter is sincere, He may grant the request, as He granted the Imams what they asked.

> ع **WORD STUDY: DUʿA AND MUNAJAT**
> *Duʿa* is the general word for supplication: any request addressed to God, in any words. A *munajat* is one kind of duʿa. The Mafatih's English calls the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah a "confidential prayer"[50], and William Chittick translates the fifteen munajat printed with the Sahifa as "whispered prayers"[51]. Both translations describe speech meant for God alone. Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi explains why the Imams' supplications reach further than their other words. In their narrations they spoke with people, whereas in their supplications they spoke with God, and the level of speech depends on the understanding of the one addressed. The Qur'an, he writes, is a "Descending-Qur'an", God's words to His servants. The supplications are an "Ascending-Qur'an", the words of His most distinguished servants rising towards Him[52].

Prayers for ordinary nights

God's invitation to recite these words comes through books that ordinary believers already use. Four of the prayers quoted in this chapter are in the Mafatih al-Jinan, the standard manual of Shia devotion[53]. The Mafatih sets each of them on a night or a day in the believer's year.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah is listed among the acts of the month of Shaʿban. The Mafatih gives a report that calls it the confidential prayer of

[49] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 164.
[50] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[51] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[52] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.
[53] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.

Imam ʿAli (as) and the Imams, which they used to say in that month[54]. It adds that it is "advisable to say it with presence of heart all the time"[55].

The other prayers have their own times. Duʿa Kumayl belongs to Thursday evenings and to the night of mid-Shaʿban[56]. Duʿa ʿArafah is the prayer of Imam al-Husayn (as) on the Day of ʿArafah[57]. Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali belongs to Ramadan; Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as) said it in the last hour of the month's nights[58]. Maliki Tabrizi tells the traveller not to forget it, every night or every other night[59].

These nights make the words familiar, and Imam Khomeini could count on it. "You are already familiar with the words used in Imams' supplications," he told his listeners, before reading them lines from the Shaʿbaniyyah[60].

⧗ HISTORY: THE MAFATIH AND THE SAHIFA

The *Mafatih al-Jinan*, "Keys to the Heavens", gathers the supplications of the Imams, the words to be recited at particular times, and the forms for visiting the Imams' shrines. Its compiler, Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, was a scholar of vast learning who died in Najaf in 1359/1940[61]. Al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya is far older. William Chittick calls it "the oldest prayer manual in Islamic sources", composed by Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as), the fourth Imam; Shia tradition ranks it behind only the Qur'an and Nahj al-Balagha[62]. The Imam died in Medina in 95/713–4, or a year earlier[63]. The fifteen whispered prayers, the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers among them, were added to several modern editions of the Sahifa. They seem to have reached most Shia through ʿAllama Muhammad Baqir Majlisi, the compiler of *Bihar al-Anwar*[64].

Familiarity with the words is not the same as reaching what they describe. Maliki Tabrizi, having called the supplications an Ascending-Qur'an, writes

[54] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[55] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.
[56] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.
[57] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 374.
[58] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 282.
[59] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 111.
[60] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 156.
[61] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.
[62] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 7.
[63] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 8.
[64] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.

that this "is not accepted and comprehended by any one, except a small number of believers who are thoroughly familiar and enlightened"[65].

Sheikh Bahmanpour still recommends the Munajat to every listener, to be recited in Shaʿban as often as they can, while granting that we do not understand many of its meanings. The two positions answer different questions. Maliki Tabrizi speaks of how far a reciter reaches; the Sheikh speaks of who may begin. What this chapter claims is access to these words, rather than attainment of what they ask for.

Words already on our lips

Access to these words is where an ordinary believer already stands on the path. Part One began with the Qur'an's invitation to more than the minimum. Chapter Two showed that the more is knowing God, not only knowing about Him, and that it is reached by purifying the heart. The prayers that believers already say ask for that same knowing, and for the love that goes with it.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, Duʿa Kumayl, Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali, and Duʿa ʿArafah ask God to cut the heart off from all else, to light it, to fill it with His love, and to bring it near. They ask in the voice of someone in need, on nights the ordinary believer keeps. The goal of ʿirfan is therefore not foreign to the believer: it is already on our lips. The full text of the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, in Arabic and English, is given in the Appendix.

These prayers keep asking God to work on the heart and the self. What is this self?

> **➤ TRY THIS**
>
> This week, read the petitions of the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah from §82 to §111 (in the Appendix) once, slowly, with the English beside the Arabic. The Mafatih advises saying the prayer "with presence of heart"[66]. As you read, notice the requests this chapter has followed: to be cut off from all else, to see, to love, and to draw near. When Shaʿban comes, follow the Sheikh's own advice and recite the whole prayer "as much as you can".

[65] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.
[66] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.